

Hosting the Career Transition Intake Form on Vercel

The intake form is a Flask web application hosted on Vercel as a Serverless (Fluid Compute) Function. It collects structured client responses across 10 sections, generates a PDF, and emails it automatically to the consultant via Resend — no SMTP configuration or credentials are shown to clients. Vercel is connected to the GitHub repo ([ericgitonga/career-transition](#), a monorepo shared with the public landing page) and redeploys the intake app automatically on every push to **main**.

After one-time setup, deploying a change means pushing to GitHub. That's it.

One-Time Setup

These steps are required once before the first deployment.

1. Create a Vercel account

Go to <https://vercel.com> and sign up with GitHub — the Hobby tier requires no credit card.

2. Import the repository as a new project

- Click **Add New** → **Project** and select the **ericgitonga/career-transition** repository
- Because this is a monorepo shared with the **landing/** Next.js app, set **Root Directory** to **intake** before the first deploy — otherwise Vercel tries to build the repo root, which isn't a valid app on its own
- Vercel auto-detects **vercel.json**'s **"framework": "flask"** setting and configures the build itself — there is no build or start command to enter manually
- Click **Deploy** for the first build (it will complete once the environment variables from step 4 are added — a failed first deploy due to a missing **RESEND_API_KEY** is expected and fine to ignore)

3. Sign up for Resend (email delivery)

Resend is a transactional email service that sends over HTTPS — it is never blocked by hosting providers the way SMTP is. The free tier allows 3,000 emails per month.

- Go to <https://resend.com> and sign up using the consultant's email address (e.g. `example@gmail.com`) — this becomes the verified recipient address
- In the Resend dashboard, go to **API Keys** → **Create API Key**
- Give it a name (e.g. *career-transition-form*) and copy the key — it is shown only once

4. Add environment variables in Vercel

In the Vercel project, go to **Settings** → **Environment Variables** and add:

- **RESEND_API_KEY** — required. The API key copied from step 3.
- **SECRET_KEY** — required in production, and specifically important on Vercel: without a fixed value the app auto-generates a random one per warm Fluid Compute instance, causing intermittent CSRF failures once real traffic is split across more than one instance. Generate one with `python -c "import secrets; print(secrets.token_hex(32))"` and set it as a fixed value — never regenerate it after clients start using the live form.
- **RATELIMIT_STORAGE_URI** — required in production. Provision a Redis database via **Storage** → **Marketplace Database Providers** → **Upstash** in the Vercel dashboard, then copy the **rediss://** connection string from the *Upstash console's own "Connect" tab* — not the REST endpoint Vercel's own integration page surfaces by default (**UPSTASH_REDIS_REST_URL/_TOKEN**), which this app's rate limiter can't use. Without this, every auto-scaled instance keeps its own separate counter, silently multiplying every rate limit.
- **FROM_EMAIL** — optional. Only needed to send from a verified custom domain instead of Resend's shared `onboarding@resend.dev` address.

The app reads all of these from the environment automatically. Never put a key or connection string in the code or the repository.

Save, then redeploy from the **Deployments** tab so the new variables take effect.

How It Works

Client experience

Clients open the URL, complete the 10-section light-themed accordion form, optionally upload documents (CV, LinkedIn export, job description, learning plan, and additional files), then click **Submit Onboarding Form**. The server generates a PDF, emails it to the consultant automatically, and triggers a download in the client's browser. No credentials, no email settings, and no configuration are shown to clients.

Email sender address

By default the form sends from **onboarding@resend.dev** (Resend's shared address). To send from a custom domain (e.g. *noreply@yourdomain.com*), verify the domain in the Resend dashboard and set the **FROM_EMAIL** environment variable in Vercel with the desired address.

Deploying Updates

Push any change to the main branch — Vercel picks it up and redeploys automatically:

```
git push origin main
```

A pull request gets its own throwaway **Preview** deployment first, so a change can be checked live before it reaches real clients; merging to **main** promotes it to **Production** at the permanent URL below.

After Deployment

Your URL

Vercel assigns a permanent URL shown at the top of the project dashboard:

```
https://career-transition-intake.vercel.app
```

This URL does not change between deploys.

Cold starts

Vercel's Fluid Compute has sub-second cold starts even after a period of inactivity — unlike a free-tier server that spins down and takes tens of seconds to wake up, there is no visible loading delay to warn clients about.

Rotating the Resend API key

Go to the Resend dashboard, revoke the old key and create a new one. Then go to **Vercel** → **Settings** → **Environment Variables**, update **RESEND_API_KEY**, and redeploy from the **Deployments** tab to apply it.